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The Year-End Money Checklist

Ten moves with real deadlines, a one-page holiday spending plan, and the checks that keep Black Friday and pay-later plans from following you into March.

FSA & 401(k) deadlines · Holiday plan in 4 numbers · Deal checks · Pay-in-4 rules



Print it, or fill it in on a tablet.

Examples are hypothetical. General education, not financial advice.

PART 1

10 money moves before January 1

Each takes 5 to 10 minutes. Do them all in an afternoon, or one a day until New Year's.

- [ ] **Spend what's left in your health FSA** — BEFORE DEC 31
  Check your balance and deadline in the benefits portal. FSAs are generally use-it-or-lose-it; some plans give a grace period or let you carry over a limited amount. Glasses, contacts, prescriptions and many over-the-counter medicines usually qualify.

- [ ] **Set next year's 401(k) percentage** — BEFORE THE LAST PAYROLL
  At least enough for the full employer match. Got a raise? Add 1%. Contributions for this year must come out of this year's paychecks, so December is the last chance to add more for 2026.

- [ ] **Run the IRS Tax Withholding Estimator** — BEFORE JANUARY
  15 minutes with a recent pay stub. If you're heading for a big refund or a bill, give payroll a new W-4 for January. Especially after a side gig, a new job or getting married.

- [ ] **Check your credit reports and consider a freeze**
  Free at AnnualCreditReport.com. Look for accounts you don't recognise and wrong late payments. A freeze at all three bureaus is free, doesn't affect your score and blocks most new-account fraud.

- [ ] **Cancel subscriptions you didn't use this fall**
  List every recurring charge from the last three months of statements. Watch for free trials from holiday sales that are about to start charging.

- [ ] **Use work perks that reset in January** — BEFORE DEC 31
  Learning stipends, wellness or phone allowances, commuter benefits. Check the benefits portal or ask HR.

- [ ] **Write down your net worth**
  Everything you own (cash, investments, retirement, car at resale value) minus everything you owe. Negative is normal early on: it's a baseline for next December.

- [ ] **List next year's known big costs**
  Car registration, insurance renewals, annual subscriptions, weddings, travel, next year's holidays. Each with its month and amount.

- [ ] **Turn them into sinking funds** — SET UP IN JANUARY
  Divide each cost by the months until it's due and automate a transfer to separate savings. Example: $600 of travel in June, starting in January, is $100 a month.

- [ ] **Pick three goals with a number, a date and an automation**
  Not "save more" but "$2,400 in the emergency fund by December, $100 every payday". Set the transfers before January 1.

Two deadlines to remember. 401(k) contributions for 2026 come from 2026 paychecks. IRA and HSA contributions for 2026 can generally be made until the tax filing deadline, April 15, 2027.

PART 2

Your holiday plan in 4 numbers

About 30 minutes. One total, four categories, one per-person gift number.

1. Your total

Money you have now or will earn this month, minus bills through month-end and a small cushion, plus anything already set aside. Not next month's paycheck, and not a card balance you'll pay off "eventually".

```
Total = checking balance - bills to month-end - cushion + money set aside =
$________
```

2. Split it four ways

GIFTS
$_____
Total for everyone on the list

TRAVEL
$_____
Door to door: gas, parking, rides, pet sitter

FOOD & HOSTING
$_____
Big meals, the dish you bring, drinks

EXTRAS
$_____
Outfits, decorations, tips, white elephant

If the four add up to more than the total, shrink the biggest one first.

3. Your per-person gift number

```
Gift total ÷ number of names = $______ each (example: $300 ÷ 12 = $25)
```

Name	Budget	Spent

4. In January: next year's fund

```
What you actually spent ÷ 12 = $______ a month into a holiday sinking fund
```

PART 3

Black Friday and checkout traps

Deals can be real. Stores are designed to make you decide fast. These checks slow it down.

Before you buy: 5 checks

- [ ] **Was it on my list before the sale?**
  If not, it goes in the cart for 24 hours. Countdown timers and "only 2 left" are there to rush you.
- [ ] **Is it really cheaper?**
  Check the price history: some "sale" prices are what it cost in October.
- [ ] **Cost per use**
  Price ÷ times you'll realistically use it. A $40 gadget used twice is $20 a use; a $90 appliance used 100 times is 90¢.
- [ ] **Which card?**
  For online shopping, a credit card you pay in full is usually safer than debit: federal law caps your liability for unauthorized credit card charges at $50, and the money doesn't leave your account while you dispute it.
- [ ] **Does it fit the category number?**
  If not, pick something else, or move money from another category on purpose.

The store card at checkout. "20% off today" often comes with deferred interest: if any of the promo balance is left when the promo ends, interest is charged all the way back to the purchase date. Store card rates are often near 30%. Unless you'd pay it in full on the first statement, say no thanks.

Pay in 4 without the hangover

- [ ] **One plan at a time**
  Stacked plans are how a $50 payment becomes a $200 week.
- [ ] **Know the late fee and where payments come from**
  An auto-pull from a thin checking account can mean a late fee and an overdraft.
- [ ] **Treat it as credit**
  Some providers report payments to the credit bureaus.
- [ ] **Only for things you could pay for today**
  It's a payment schedule, not extra money.

Sources: IRS Publication 969 and Tax Withholding Estimator (irs.gov); CFPB on deferred interest and buy now, pay later (consumerfinance.gov); FTC on credit freezes and lost or stolen cards (consumer.ftc.gov); AnnualCreditReport.com. Checked November 2026. Examples are hypothetical. General education, not financial, tax or legal advice.